Business Academy Group Learning: Recordkeeping

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Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers leave with a simple weekly recordkeeping routine and one system change to start before their next coaching session. This is the January 2027 session in the Year 2 calendar.

Item	Detail
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Slides or this guide, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout, sample receipts, a shoebox and a labeled folder for the demo, sticky notes
Ask providers to bring	A phone, and a recent month of receipts or a bank statement (kept private)

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. Name the records their program must keep and how long to keep them.
2. Set up a simple system to capture receipts, income, and attendance.
3. Commit to a weekly 30-minute recordkeeping routine.
4. Use their records to update the Budgeting Tool with actual income and expenses.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: "The shoebox question"
0:05 – 0:15	Why recordkeeping matters and what records to keep
0:15 – 0:30	Tips and tricks, with a live system demo
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: build your weekly routine
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why recordkeeping matters

Good records turn the Budgeting Tool from a guess into a true picture of the business. Use these talking points for the first 15 minutes.

Opener, "The shoebox question": Ask providers to raise a hand, or answer in chat, for where their receipts live right now: a shoebox, a purse, the car, a folder, an app. Keep it light; most people will laugh at themselves. Then ask, "If someone asked what you spent on food last month, how long would it take you to answer?"

Talking points:

- **Your budget is only as good as your records.** Monthly coaching compares the Budgeting Tool to actual income and expenses. Without records, the actuals are a guess.
- **Records protect money you have already earned.** Missing receipts mean missed tax deductions. This matters most for home-based providers, who can deduct part of their home costs.
- **Records are required.** Licensing, the Child Care Subsidy Program, the food program (CACFP), grants, and the IRS all expect documentation.
- **Records support decisions.** They show whether you can afford a raise for teachers, which months are tight, and what tuition you really need to charge.

- **Records save time and stress.** Tax season, an inspection, or a grant report becomes a matter of pulling a folder, not searching the house.
- **Records make you fundable.** Lenders and grant makers want to see clean books before they invest.

What records to keep

Most child care records fall into six groups. A simple, safe rule for providers: keep financial and tax records for at least 7 years.

Record group	Examples	Suggested time to keep
Income	Tuition and fee records, invoices and receipts given to families, subsidy payments, CACFP reimbursements, grants, bank deposits	7 years
Expenses	Receipts for food, supplies, toys, rent or mortgage, utilities, insurance, repairs, training, advertising; credit card and bank statements	7 years
Payroll and staff	Timesheets, pay stubs, payroll tax filings, W-2s, 1099s for contractors, I-9s, staff files	At least 4 years for payroll tax records; staff files per licensing
Attendance and enrollment	Daily sign-in/sign-out sheets, enrollment forms, subsidy attendance	Per licensing standards and your subsidy vendor agreement
Home business use (home-based)	Time-space log of hours and rooms used for child care, mileage log, home expense bills	7 years
Big purchases and legal	Equipment and vehicle purchase records, leases, contracts, insurance policies, licenses	As long as you own the item or the agreement is active, plus 7 years

These time frames are general guidance, not tax or legal advice. Providers should confirm with their tax preparer, the Virginia Department of Education licensing standards, and their subsidy vendor agreement.

Tips and tricks

Demo the "one folder, one account, one time" setup live, then walk through the tips sheet with providers: Tips and Tricks. Hand out the checklist at the end: Provider Handout.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Pick your system (folder or app) and label it with the Budgeting Tool categories. Open a separate business account if you don't have one.	System is set up
Week 2	Gather last month's receipts and statements; file or scan them by category. Start snapping receipts at the store.	Last month is filed
Week 3	Hold your first 30-minute weekly session on your chosen day. Home-based providers start a time-space and mileage log.	Routine is on your calendar
Week 4	Close out the month: total income and expenses and enter them in the Budgeting Tool.	Budgeting Tool shows actuals

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- [ ] Ask which system the provider chose and whether the weekly routine stuck
- [ ] Review the Budgeting Tool's actual income and expenses against the records
- [ ] Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record
- [ ] Help solve one sticking point (for example, cash payments or mixed receipts)

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- My recordkeeping system will be: _____
- My weekly records time is: ____ day at ____
- The one change I will make this month: _____
- I'll update my Budgeting Tool by: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these five points aloud; they also go on the handout.

1. **Separate your money.** A business account is the foundation of good records.
2. **One place, every time.** Pick one system for receipts and stick with it.
3. **Capture it now.** Snap receipts before you leave the store.
4. **30 minutes a week beats 3 days in April.** A small weekly routine prevents the year-end scramble.
5. **Records feed your budget.** Close out each month and update the Budgeting Tool before coaching.

Activities and discussion

One hands-on activity anchors the session, and the discussion questions carry over into the January Peer Connections session.

Activity: Sort the receipts (10 minutes, during tips and tricks)

Hand each small group a stack of 10–12 sample receipts (groceries, art supplies, a utility bill, a gas receipt, a mixed shopping trip with personal items, a faded receipt). Groups sort them into Budgeting Tool categories and flag any problems. Debrief: Which were hard to place? What would have made it easier?

Activity: Build your weekly routine (15 minutes)

Each provider fills in the commitment card, then shares their chosen day and time with a partner. Partners agree to check in with each other by text after week 2.

Discussion questions

- Where do your receipts end up today, and what's one thing that would change that?
- What's the hardest record for you to keep up with, and why?
- Has a missing record ever cost you money or time? What happened?
- What would you do with an extra few hours at tax time?

Peer Connections prompt (January)

"How do you track income and expenses week to week?" Ask each provider to share one tool or habit that works for them, and one they gave up on. Collect the best ideas into a shared tip sheet for the group.